

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 5

Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	15 — Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct.

Apex traps demand multi-step synthesis: a creative (not 'dark') age proven by simultaneous monuments, universities, zero and Bhakti; Arab rule confined to Sindh after 712 CE by Indian resistance, never 'most of India'; a three-sided (not two-sided) Tripartite Struggle for Kanauj among Palas, Gurjara-Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas; a layered, indirect monarchy through samantas and self-governing sabhas, not direct rule; a flexible, regionally varied jati system; and source-criticism where every prashasti, traveller's account and coin is weighed against independent evidence. Distractors are built from plausible expert errors: swapped dynasty-monument pairs, reversed Alvar/Nayanar deities, mis-located capitals, and conflated dates. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A historian compiles four dated facts: Harsha's rise (c. 606 CE), the Arab capture of Sindh (712 CE), Brahmagupta's mathematical work (7th century), and Kalhana's Rajatarangini (12th century). She wants the one fact that, by itself, most directly disproves the claim 'nothing intellectual was produced between the Guptas and 1200 CE.' Which should she pick?

- (A) Brahmagupta's 7th-century rules for calculating with zero, an original advance made within the disputed centuries
- (B) Harsha's rise in c. 606 CE, because it shows the north still had a strong king
- (C) Kalhana's Rajatarangini, because being from the 12th century it falls outside the disputed centuries
- (D) the Arab capture of Sindh in 712 CE, because conquest is itself an intellectual achievement

2. Two museum panels disagree. Panel A: 'The post-Gupta centuries were dark because no single emperor unified India.' Panel B: 'They were creative precisely because no single emperor unified India.' The chapter's reasoning supports Panel B because:

- (A) fragmentation forced all kingdoms to pool their treasuries into one shared building fund
- (B) the absence of an emperor meant taxes vanished, leaving people free to build for themselves
- (C) only a divided land could attract Arab patrons who paid for the temples and universities
- (D) many rival courts competed as patrons, each funding temples and scholars to outshine its neighbours, so fragmentation multiplied rather than starved cultural sponsorship

3. A copper-plate grant lavishly praises King X and lists his conquest of a neighbour; a coin hoard from that neighbour's region still bears the neighbour's name and royal titles for the same years. The soundest conclusion a Class-7 historian should draw is that:

- (A) the grant is automatically correct because a royal inscription is an official document
- (B) the coins are automatically correct because metal lasts longer than copper plates
- (C) both sources are worthless, so nothing can be known about the relationship between the two kings
- (D) the prashasti likely exaggerates X's success, since independent coin evidence suggests the neighbour still ruled, so both sources must be weighed together

4. An exhibit shows a monolithic, chariot-shaped stone shrine excavated on the Tamil coast near a former capital called Kanchi. A second exhibit shows a far larger single-rock temple carved downward in the Deccan. The correct attribution and the key distinction are:

- (A) both are Pallava works, the coastal one at Mahabalipuram and the Deccan one transported inland
- (B) the coastal chariot-shrine is a Pallava ratha at Mahabalipuram; the larger downward-carved Deccan temple is the Rashtrakuta Kailasa at Ellora, the bigger of the two
- (C) the coastal shrine is a Rashtrakuta ratha and the Deccan temple is the Pallava Kailasa
- (D) the coastal shrine is a Pala work from Bengal and the Deccan temple a Chalukya one from Vatapi

5. The Rashtrakutas were based in the Deccan, yet they repeatedly marched far north to fight for Kanauj. The deepest reason this behaviour is historically significant is that it shows:

- (A) the Rashtrakutas had lost their Deccan homeland and needed any city to govern
- (B) Kanauj was the subcontinent's only gold mine, making the marches purely economic
- (C) the Rashtrakutas were Arab allies advancing the conquest of Sindh northward
- (D) Kanauj functioned as a prestige symbol of supremacy over the north, so even a distant power treated controlling it as worth the cost, revealing a contested balance with no single dominant empire

6. A student argues: 'Because the Tripartite Struggle went on for generations with no permanent winner, the period must have been chaotic and politically weak.' The best correction is that the prolonged stalemate instead indicates:

- (A) a single unbeatable empire that deliberately prolonged the fighting for sport
- (B) total political collapse in which no kingdom had any real army
- (C) several strong, roughly evenly matched regional kingdoms in a shifting balance of power, none able to dominate the rest for long
- (D) foreign Arab rule over the whole north that the three dynasties were jointly resisting

7. Assertion: The Gurjara-Pratiharas' control of the north-west had consequences far beyond their own kingdom. Reason: By holding that frontier they helped keep Arab power confined to Sindh. The correct evaluation is:

- (A) both statements are true, and the reason correctly explains the assertion
- (B) both statements are true, but the reason does not explain the assertion
- (C) the assertion is true but the reason is false
- (D) the assertion is false but the reason is true

8. Xuanzang, a Chinese Buddhist monk, wrote glowingly of Nalanda and Harsha's just rule. A historian notes two things at once: his account is valuable, yet his being a Buddhist monk shapes it. The best combined judgement is:

- (A) treat it as one valuable eyewitness source while allowing that his Buddhist devotion may give Buddhist centres unusually warm emphasis, and cross-check it against inscriptions and coins
- (B) accept every detail as exact, because an eyewitness monk could not be mistaken about what he saw
- (C) reject the whole account, because a monk's religious bias makes all his observations false
- (D) use it as the only permitted source on this age and set aside Indian inscriptions and coins

9. A timeline lists: (i) early Arab raids repulsed from about 637 CE, (ii) the Arab capture of Sindh in 712 CE, (iii) Arab power still confined to Sindh for long after. Read together, these three best support the conclusion that:

- (A) the Arabs faced no resistance and simply chose, twice, not to expand
- (B) the Arabs conquered most of India by 712 and only later withdrew to Sindh
- (C) the Chinese army was responsible for stopping the Arabs on both occasions
- (D) sustained Indian resistance both delayed and then contained the Arab advance, so it never extended much beyond Sindh

10. A villager's land in a Chola territory is described in records as: assigned by a royal land grant to a temple, irrigated by a village tank, with disputes settled by an elected sabha. Synthesising these, the most accurate single statement about Chola-age society is that:

- (A) the king personally managed the land, the water and every village dispute himself
- (B) the village was wholly autonomous, with no connection to king, temple or wider state
- (C) royal patronage, communal water management and local self-government operated together in a layered, organised order beneath the king
- (D) foreign Arab governors controlled the grant, the tank and the assembly

11. The Uttaramerur inscriptions are prized chiefly because they record how members of a village assembly were chosen. A historian wanting firsthand evidence on Chola local self-government should therefore prefer them over Xuanzang's account because:

- (A) Xuanzang's account is fiction, whereas all inscriptions are works of imagination
- (B) Xuanzang wrote in Tamil and so could not describe northern India
- (C) the inscriptions are local, official records of the very procedures in question, while Xuanzang's is a foreign traveller's broad impression of a different region and time
- (D) the inscriptions are royal prashastis praising the king's personal rule of each village

12. The chapter says the Palas may have risen from a humbler social background to kingship, and that a profession such as that of the Kayasthas could harden into a jati. Used together, these two examples are meant to establish that:

- (A) caste in this age was completely rigid, so the two examples must be later inventions
- (B) there were in fact no jatis at all in this period
- (C) every person in the subcontinent belonged to one single, identical group
- (D) the varna-jati order of this age was flexible and changing, with status mobile and new jatis forming, not fixed for all time

13. Brahmagupta worked in the 7th century; the Arab conquest of Sindh fell in the 8th; Kalhana's Rajatarangini was written in the 12th. A student must place 'the rules of zero', 'the loss of Sindh', and 'the Kashmir chronicle' in earliest-to-latest order. The correct order is:

- (A) the loss of Sindh, then the rules of zero, then the Kashmir chronicle
- (B) the Kashmir chronicle, then the rules of zero, then the loss of Sindh
- (C) the rules of zero, then the Kashmir chronicle, then the loss of Sindh
- (D) the rules of zero, then the loss of Sindh, then the Kashmir chronicle

14. An inscription notes that a merchant guild repaired a village tank, and a royal grant assigned that tank's revenues to a temple. A student says this proves the economy had collapsed. The best correction is that the inscription actually shows:

- (A) trade bodies, irrigation works and royal grants working together in a managed, productive economy
- (B) an economy reduced to silent barter with no guilds or money
- (C) that all land and water had passed under direct Arab control
- (D) that villages had no organised water supply and no commerce of any kind

15. Why does the chapter treat the existence of self-governing sabhas as evidence about the NATURE of royal power, rather than merely a local curiosity?

- (A) because sabhas proved the king had no power at all and India was a republic
- (B) because sabhas were assemblies of samantas who together replaced the king
- (C) because sabhas were branches of a single national parliament that governed every village
- (D) because they show royal authority flowed down through layers — king to samantas to village assemblies — so the monarchy was indirect, not a king ruling each villager personally

16. A scholar contrasts two southern dynasties: one based at Kanchi on the Tamil coast, the other at Vatapi (Badami) in the Deccan, long rivals who each patronised temple art. The correct identification is:

- (A) the Kanchi power was the Chalukyas and the Vatapi power the Pallavas
- (B) both Kanchi and Vatapi were Pala capitals in Bengal
- (C) Kanchi was the Pallava capital and Vatapi an Arab base in the Deccan
- (D) the coastal Kanchi power was the Pallavas and the Deccan Vatapi power the Chalukyas, southern rivals rather than allies

17. A student lists 'achievements that prove the post-Gupta age was creative': the rules of zero, the Bhakti hymns, the Buddhist universities, the Kailasa temple, and the Arab conquest of Sindh. To make the list logically valid the student must:

- (A) remove the rules of zero, because mathematics is not culture
- (B) remove the Arab conquest of Sindh, because it is a foreign military event, not an Indian cultural or intellectual achievement of the period
- (C) remove the Bhakti hymns, because devotion is not an achievement
- (D) keep all five, because every event of the period counts as an achievement that disproves the dark-age label

18. Nalanda and Vikramashila admitted students only after examination by a dvarapandita and drew monks from across Asia. Combining the selectivity with the international draw, the strongest inference is that these universities were:

- (A) rigorous, high-standard institutions whose reputation connected India to a wider Asian world of learning
- (B) open to anyone who arrived, which is why students came from far away
- (C) military camps disguised as schools, which is why entry was guarded
- (D) purely local schools cut off from any contact beyond Bengal

19. The Alvars and the Nayanars were early Tamil Bhakti poet-saints. A quiz states 'the Alvars sang of Shiva and the Nayanars of Vishnu.' The correction is that:

- (A) the statement is correct as written
- (B) the Alvars were devoted to Vishnu and the Nayanars to Shiva, so the pairing is reversed
- (C) both groups were devoted only to the Buddha
- (D) the Alvars were Chinese pilgrims and the Nayanars Arab generals

20. Bhakti is said to differ from older formal Vedic practice. The single contrast that best captures the chapter's point is that Bhakti:

- (A) was restricted to kings, while Vedic ritual was open to all
- (B) reached ordinary people through personal, loving devotion in local languages, whereas formal Vedic worship was priest-centred and built around sacrifice
- (C) relied on grand public sacrifices, while Vedic worship stressed private devotion
- (D) was a foreign religion brought by the Arabs, while Vedic worship was indigenous

21. A king of this age grants away tax rights over a tract of land to a temple, and elsewhere rules a distant province through a samanta who supplies tribute and troops. Taken together, these arrangements most directly show that royal power was:

- (A) absolute and direct, with the king personally collecting every tax and governing every province
- (B) indirect and layered, depending on landholders and subordinate rulers, so the king's real strength rested on their continued loyalty
- (C) non-existent, since granting land and using samantas means the king had given everything away
- (D) exercised only through a nationwide vote that chose both temples and samantas

22. An assertion-reason item reads — Assertion: A single prashasti is not enough to settle whether a king truly won a battle. Reason: A prashasti is composed to praise its ruler and may exaggerate. The correct evaluation is:

- (A) both statements are true, and the reason correctly explains the assertion
- (B) both statements are true, but the reason does not explain the assertion
- (C) the assertion is true but the reason is false
- (D) the assertion is false but the reason is true

23. Match three powers to their regions for a map exercise: which list runs correctly from the north-west, through the Deccan, to the east?

- (A) Palas in the north-west, Pratiharas in the Deccan, Rashtrakutas in the east
- (B) Rashtrakutas in the north-west, Palas in the Deccan, Pratiharas in the east
- (C) Gurjara-Pratiharas in the north-west, Rashtrakutas in the Deccan, Palas in Bengal in the east
- (D) Pallavas in the north-west, Cholas in the Deccan, Cheras in the east

24. A student claims, 'Since Xuanzang praised Harsha's India as prosperous, prosperity is proven.' The deepest flaw in this single-source reasoning is that:

- (A) Xuanzang never actually travelled to India, so his account is invented
- (B) prosperity is something no historical source could ever indicate
- (C) one observer's impression may be partial or idealised, so the claim must be tested against inscriptions, coins and local records before it counts as established
- (D) only coins can prove anything, so a written account is automatically useless

25. A 'monolithic' temple and a temple 'built up from cut blocks' are contrasted. Why is calling Ellora's Kailasa temple monolithic the very thing that makes it an extraordinary feat of the age?

- (A) because monolithic means it was assembled from the largest available marble bricks
- (B) because monolithic means it was the first temple cast entirely in iron
- (C) because monolithic means it was the largest wooden temple ever raised
- (D) because the whole temple was carved downward out of a single mass of living rock, so a single mistake could not be undone, unlike a block-built structure

26. Two students debate the Kanauj contest. One insists it was a two-power fight between the Palas and Pratiharas; the other says three powers were involved. The single decisive point in favour of the three-power view is that:

- (A) the Rashtrakutas of the Deccan repeatedly intervened alongside the Palas and Pratiharas, making the rivalry three-sided
- (B) the Cholas of the Tamil south were the third power contending for Kanauj
- (C) the Guptas remained one of the three powers fighting for Kanauj
- (D) only the Palas and Pratiharas ever sent armies toward Kanauj, confirming two sides

27. A copper-plate grant, a temple prashasti, and a foreign traveller's diary all describe the same king. A historian ranks them by how much independent checking each needs before trusting its praise of the king. The soundest principle is that:

- (A) the foreign diary needs no checking because outsiders are always neutral
- (B) all three carry a viewpoint — the grant and prashasti favour the king, the diary reflects an outsider's standpoint — so each must be weighed against the others and against coins
- (C) the prashasti needs no checking because temple records are sacred and exact
- (D) the copper-plate grant needs no checking because it is an official royal document

28. The chapter notes that some queens and women in this age held real influence. The most accurate reading of this point, kept within what the chapter claims, is that:

- (A) women were entirely absent from public life throughout the age
- (B) individual queens each ruled the whole subcontinent on their own
- (C) women were forbidden any role outside the household by royal decree
- (D) women could exercise genuine power and influence in public affairs in this period, though the chapter does not claim any single queen ruled the whole subcontinent

29. A student summarises: 'The age had no empire, so it had no culture; the Arabs took most of India in 712; and the Tripartite Struggle was a two-power fight.' How many of the three claims are wrong, and what is the corrected picture?

- (A) none are wrong: the age was cultureless, the Arabs took most of India, and two powers fought
- (B) only one is wrong: just the claim about the Tripartite Struggle
- (C) only the dark-age claim is wrong; the other two statements are correct
- (D) all three are wrong: no empire yet culture thrived, the Arabs took only Sindh, and the struggle was three-sided

30. Epigraphy and numismatics are two of the historian's tools for this age. A question asks which pairing of tool to object is correct:

- (A) epigraphy studies coins; numismatics studies inscriptions on stone or metal
- (B) epigraphy studies the stars; numismatics studies travel diaries
- (C) epigraphy studies travel diaries; numismatics studies temple architecture
- (D) epigraphy studies inscriptions carved on stone or metal, such as copper-plate grants; numismatics studies coins

31. The Rajatarangini is described as unusual among early Indian texts. The single feature that makes it so, and its author, are correctly given as:

- (A) Brahmagupta's treatise, unusual because it sets out the rules of zero in verse
- (B) Kalhana's 12th-century work, unusual because it sets out Kashmir's dynastic history in chronological order, a rare formal history
- (C) an Alvar's composition, unusual because it is a Tamil devotional poem about Vishnu
- (D) an Arab official's account, unusual because it records the conquest of Sindh

32. Both the Palas (supporting Nalanda and Vikramashila) and the early Cholas (recording assembly rules at Uttaramerur) are cited together. The single broad point they jointly illustrate is that:

- (A) only one northern empire ever patronised any culture in this age
- (B) kingdoms of this age generally destroyed schools and village assemblies
- (C) all cultural and civic life depended on the Arab rulers of Sindh
- (D) different regional kingdoms each fostered learning and institutions in their own way, so cultural and civic vitality was spread across many courts

33. A 'land grant', a 'samanta' and a 'sabha' are three pillars of the period's order. Which single statement correctly relates all three?

- (A) a land grant created landholders, a samanta governed an outer region for the king in return for tribute and troops, and a sabha let a village govern many of its own affairs
- (B) a land grant abolished landholding, a samanta was a village assembly, and a sabha was a subordinate ruler
- (C) a land grant was a devotional poem, a samanta a coin, and a sabha a chariot-shaped temple
- (D) a land grant, a samanta and a sabha were all titles for the single all-powerful emperor

34. A textbook draft says: 'The Pallavas built Nalanda, the Palas carved the Ellora Kailasa, and the Rashtrakutas raised the Mahabalipuram rathas.' How many of the three dynasty-monument pairings are correct?

- (A) none of the three is correct; each monument belongs to a different dynasty
- (B) exactly one is correct
- (C) exactly two are correct
- (D) all three are correct

35. A guide claims, 'The post-Gupta centuries can be summed up as one peaceful empire that quietly preserved the old culture.' Two separate errors must be fixed. They are that the period was instead:

- (A) one empire as stated, but a violently destructive age rather than a peaceful one
- (B) many competing kingdoms rather than one empire, and a creatively productive age rather than a merely preserving one
- (C) many kingdoms as a correction, but indeed culturally stagnant and merely preserving
- (D) one peaceful empire, correct in both respects, needing no fixing at all

36. A museum wants the single object that would best prove, on its own, that Chola villages chose their assembly members by a defined procedure. The curator should choose:

- (A) a coin bearing a Chola king's portrait and titles
- (B) a copy of Xuanzang's travel account of Harsha's north India
- (C) an Uttaramerur-type inscription recording the rules for selecting sabha members
- (D) a monolithic ratha carved on the Tamil coast

37. Why is it sound for historians to value humble copper-plate grants and village inscriptions even more highly than grand royal chronicles for reconstructing daily life in this age?

- (A) because they are always written by neutral foreign observers with no bias
- (B) because they describe only the private feelings and dreams of kings

- (C) because they record everyday matters — land, taxes, water and assemblies — that royal chronicles and travelogues often omit
- (D) because they are the only sources from the age that ever exaggerate

38. A student reasons: 'Because Brahmagupta gave the rules of zero in the 7th century, the dark-age label is wrong even for the centuries that came after him.' The strongest support for extending the rebuttal beyond Brahmagupta's own time is that:

- (A) Brahmagupta personally kept working until 1200 CE, covering the whole span himself
- (B) the rules of zero made all later building and learning unnecessary, ending the debate
- (C) nothing else of note happened after Brahmagupta, so his single work must carry the whole span
- (D) later centuries also produced the rock-cut temples, the great universities and the Bhakti movement, so creativity continued across the whole period, not just in Brahmagupta's lifetime

39. An exam item pairs each term with a meaning. Which pairing is fully correct?

- (A) a ratha is a man-made reservoir, and a tank is a chariot-shaped shrine
- (B) a ratha is a subordinate ruler, and a tank is a village assembly
- (C) a ratha is a shrine carved to resemble a chariot, and a tank (eri) is a man-made reservoir for storing rainwater
- (D) a ratha is a Buddhist university, and a tank is a Chinese pilgrim

40. A historian argues that the very thing critics call 'weakness' — the lack of one empire — actually helped Indian temple art. The best evidence she could cite from this chapter is that:

- (A) Rashtrakutas, Pallavas and Palas, as separate competing courts, each sponsored distinct great works — Ellora, Mahabalipuram and Nalanda respectively
- (B) a single emperor commissioned Ellora, Mahabalipuram and Nalanda from one capital
- (C) the Arabs of Sindh funded all three monuments as a unified project
- (D) all building stopped until one empire was re-established after 1200 CE

41. Assertion: The Arabs failed to push much beyond Sindh after 712 CE. Reason: There was no organised resistance, so the Arabs simply chose not to advance. The correct evaluation is:

- (A) both statements are true, and the reason explains the assertion
- (B) the assertion is true but the reason is false, since strong Indian rulers such as the Gurjara-Pratiharas and Lalitaditya actively contained the advance
- (C) both statements are false
- (D) the assertion is false but the reason is true

42. A coin hoard, a prashasti, and a foreign travelogue all touch on the same reign. A student asks which can establish a fact most reliably on its own. The best answer reflecting the chapter's method is that:

- (A) the prashasti alone, because it is the most detailed and was officially issued
- (B) no single source is reliable on its own; a firmer fact emerges only where independent sources of different kinds agree after cross-checking
- (C) the travelogue alone, because an eyewitness saw events directly
- (D) the coin alone, because metal evidence cannot be biased in any way

43. The chapter places the Tripartite Struggle in the context of 'no single dominant emperor after Harsha'. The clearest logical link between these two facts is that:

- (A) Harsha's heirs deliberately organised the struggle as a contest to choose a successor
- (B) the Arabs created the vacuum by removing Harsha's dynasty from Kanauj
- (C) the absence of one paramount northern emperor created the power vacuum that several regional dynasties then fought to fill at Kanauj
- (D) the struggle ended Harsha's reign, after which a single emperor took over

44. A teacher writes 'flexible, regionally varied' beside the caste system and asks which observation does NOT belong as evidence for it. The observation that does NOT belong is:

- (A) that the Palas are said to have risen from a humbler background to kingship
- (B) that a profession such as that of the Kayasthas could harden into a distinct jati
- (C) that every person in the subcontinent belonged to one single, identical group
- (D) that jatis multiplied and varied from region to region across the period

45. A debate motion reads: 'Royal inscriptions are the most trustworthy single window into a king's true achievements.' The strongest rebuttal grounded in this chapter is that:

- (A) royal inscriptions are written in languages no historian can read, so they are useless
- (B) royal inscriptions record only weather and crops, never a king's deeds
- (C) royal inscriptions such as prashastis are composed to glorify the ruler, so they may exaggerate and must be checked against coins, rival inscriptions and other records
- (D) royal inscriptions were all destroyed in this age, leaving only travelogues

46. Two facts are given: monks from across Asia studied at Nalanda, and a dvarapandita examined applicants at Vikramashila. A student concludes 'India in this age was an isolated backwater with low academic standards.' Both halves of this conclusion are wrong because:

- (A) the international draw shows India was connected to a wider world, and the entrance examination shows high, not low, academic standards
- (B) the international draw proves isolation, while the examination proves low standards
- (C) both facts are inventions, so no conclusion about India's standing can be drawn
- (D) the facts concern only Bengal, so they say nothing about academic standards anywhere

47. A king assigns a samanta to a frontier province; years later that samanta withholds tribute and acts on his own. The chapter would treat this episode as illustrating that:

- (A) the king had been personally governing the province all along, so nothing changed
- (B) samantas had no duties to the king, so withholding tribute broke no arrangement
- (C) because authority was indirect and layered, a king's real power depended on keeping subordinate rulers loyal, and that loyalty could falter
- (D) the episode proves India was governed by a single nationwide vote

48. An item asks for the dynasty whose works best embody the chapter's claim that the age 'carved temples directly out of solid rock'. The best single answer, naming both a representative dynasty and its work, is:

- (A) the Palas, whose Nalanda was carved as one piece of stone
- (B) the Gurjara-Pratiharas, whose north-western forts were single rocks
- (C) the Cholas, whose irrigation tanks were hewn from solid stone
- (D) the Rashtrakutas, whose monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora was carved downward from one rock mass

49. Which single statement is fully accurate about the Arab presence in the subcontinent across this age?

- (A) the Arabs held Sindh from 712 CE but were kept from expanding much further by Indian resistance
- (B) the Arabs conquered the whole subcontinent and ruled it directly until modern times
- (C) the Arabs attacked but were defeated and never held any territory at all
- (D) the Arabs ruled Bengal and the Tamil south but somehow never held Sindh itself

50. A summary sentence must combine three ideas correctly: the period's politics, its culture, and the Arab presence. Which sentence is fully accurate?

- (A) no single empire ruled, yet temples, universities and new ideas flourished, while the Arabs held only Sindh
- (B) one empire ruled the whole land, culture declined, and the Arabs held only Sindh
- (C) no single empire ruled, culture flourished, and the Arabs ruled most of India
- (D) one empire ruled the whole land, culture flourished, and the Arabs held nothing

51. A student maps cause and effect: 'The Pratiharas guarded the north-west, therefore the Arabs were confined to Sindh, therefore the rest of India developed under its own regional kingdoms undisturbed by Arab conquest.' This chain is best judged as:

- (A) unsound, because containing the Arabs would actually have invited deeper conquest
- (B) sound, because each step follows: frontier defence contained the Arabs, and containment left the interior free to develop under Indian dynasties

- (C) unsound, because the Pratiharas were themselves Arab governors of Sindh
- (D) unsound, because the rest of India was in fact ruled directly by the Arabs

52. A curator must label a gallery of this age with one theme that ties together land grants, merchant guilds and irrigation tanks. The most accurate single theme is:

- (A) an economy in total ruin with farming and trade abandoned
- (B) a purely barter economy with no organised trade or coinage
- (C) a productive economy under deliberate management of land, trade and water beneath the kings
- (D) an economy run entirely by Arab merchants based in Sindh

53. Two assertions are tested. Assertion: Harsha was the last ruler to dominate the north for this era. Reason: After him, several powers contested Kanauj because no single emperor held the north. Which evaluation is correct?

- (A) both statements are true, and the reason correctly explains why Harsha's dominance is called the last of its kind
- (B) both are true, but the reason is unrelated to the assertion
- (C) the assertion is true but the reason is false, since one emperor did dominate after Harsha
- (D) the assertion is false, since the north had many dominant emperors after Harsha

54. A scholar says, 'The same broad lesson is taught by Brahmagupta's zero, by Nalanda's renown, and by the Uttaramerur assembly rules.' The single lesson that genuinely unites all three is that:

- (A) all three were the work of a single emperor ruling the whole land
- (B) in an age of many kingdoms, intellectual, educational and civic life all advanced, refuting the dark-age and 'no-institutions' views together
- (C) all three were produced under direct Arab rule from Sindh
- (D) all three show that learning and self-government collapsed in this age

55. A worksheet asks for the one pairing in which BOTH the place and its associated dynasty or feature are stated correctly. The correct pairing is:

- (A) Ellora in the Deccan — Buddhist university of the Palas
- (B) Mahabalipuram on the Tamil coast — rock-cut rathas of the Pallavas
- (C) Nalanda in Bengal — monolithic chariot-temple of the Rashtrakutas
- (D) Vatapi in the Tamil region — capital of the Pallavas

56. A student wants the strongest single counter-example to the statement 'after the Guptas, India built nothing of lasting grandeur in stone.' The best counter-example is:

- (A) Brahmagupta's rules of zero, which proves stone-building flourished
- (B) the monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora, an entire temple carved from one rock and still standing

- (C) the Bhakti hymns of the Alvars, which are grand works carved in stone
- (D) the Arab conquest of Sindh, which left lasting stone monuments across India

57. A historian explains why the period 600–1200 CE is best called an age of 'regional kingdoms' rather than either 'one empire' or 'no states'. The reasoning that fits the chapter is that:

- (A) there were no organised states, only scattered villages with no rulers
- (B) there was one continuous empire whose provinces are mistaken for separate kingdoms
- (C) there were many organised, competing kingdoms with real courts, armies and patronage, but none expanded into a single all-India empire
- (D) there were no kingdoms in India, only Arab provinces ruled from Sindh

58. Four students each give a one-line verdict on the post-Gupta centuries. Which verdict is BOTH internally consistent AND matches the chapter?

- (A) 'A unified empire that nonetheless produced no art, because unity stifles creativity.'
- (B) 'A stateless age that still built great universities, because villages funded them without any kings.'
- (C) 'A politically divided but culturally creative age in which rival kingdoms patronised art, learning and new devotion.'
- (D) 'An age of total foreign rule that yet flourished under Indian patrons of culture.'

59. A final synthesis asks: which single sentence correctly distinguishes the kinds of sources a historian uses for this age and what each is best for?

- (A) a prashasti best reveals village self-government, while an Uttaramerur inscription best reveals an outsider's impression of the king
- (B) a prashasti best reveals how a king wished to be seen, an Uttaramerur-type inscription best reveals village self-government, and Xuanzang's travelogue best reveals an outsider's impression to be cross-checked
- (C) Xuanzang's travelogue best reveals exact village assembly rules, while inscriptions reveal only foreign impressions
- (D) all three sources are interchangeable, each equally good for every kind of question

60. A debater claims that because Bhakti spread in local languages and the Buddhist universities drew scholars from abroad, 'the age must have had either purely local culture or purely foreign culture, but not both.' The best resolution within the chapter is that:

- (A) the age sustained both at once — devotion rooted in local languages and learning connected to a wider Asian world — so local and outward-facing culture coexisted
- (B) only local culture existed, and the foreign scholars at Nalanda are a later legend
- (C) only foreign culture existed, and Bhakti's local languages were really imported from abroad
- (D) neither existed, because in a fragmented age no culture of any kind could spread

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries — Paper 5

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, -1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	A	11	C	21	B	31	B	41	B	51	B
2	D	12	D	22	A	32	D	42	B	52	C
3	D	13	D	23	C	33	A	43	C	53	A
4	B	14	A	24	C	34	A	44	C	54	B
5	D	15	D	25	D	35	B	45	C	55	B
6	C	16	D	26	A	36	C	46	A	56	B
7	A	17	B	27	B	37	C	47	C	57	C
8	A	18	A	28	D	38	D	48	D	58	C
9	D	19	B	29	D	39	C	49	A	59	B
10	C	20	B	30	D	40	A	50	A	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (A) The claim attacked is specifically about intellectual barrenness, so the decisive fact must be an original work of thought made inside the period. Brahmagupta's rules of zero are exactly that — a 7th-century Indian mathematical advance. Harsha's rise shows political strength, not intellectual output, so it misses the point being rebutted. Kalhana's work, dated to the 12th century, lies at the very edge or just outside the 'after the Guptas to 1200 CE' window and is a history of an earlier age rather than evidence from the heart of the disputed centuries, making it weaker for this exact purpose. A military conquest is not an intellectual achievement and in any case it was a foreign one, so it cannot show Indian thought flourishing.

2. (D) The chapter's logic is that political fragmentation created several competing patrons rather than one, so courts vied with each other in sponsoring art and learning — Rashtrakutas at Ellora, Pallavas at Mahabalipuram, Palas at Nalanda. The idea that rivals

pooled treasuries into one fund contradicts the very rivalry that drove the patronage. The notion that taxes vanished is false, since land grants, guilds and tanks show an organised, revenue-bearing economy. Attributing the monuments to Arab patrons is wrong because Arab presence was confined to Sindh and the monuments were built by Indian dynasties.

3. (D) A prashasti praises its own ruler and can exaggerate, while coins issued in a region are evidence of who actually held authority there; when they conflict, the historian cross-checks and leans toward the independent coin evidence rather than the self-praising grant. Treating the grant as automatically true ignores its boastful purpose. Treating the coins as right merely because metal lasts longer confuses durability with reliability — the point is independence of the source, not its material. Declaring both worthless throws away usable evidence; the method is to weigh sources against each other, not discard them.

4. (B) Kanchi was the Pallava capital and the rathas of Mahabalipuram are Pallava rock-cut chariot shrines; the colossal single-rock Kailasa temple at Ellora is a Rashtrakuta achievement in the Deccan and is markedly larger. Saying both are Pallava and one was 'transported' is impossible for a monolith carved in place. Swapping the dynasties — Rashtrakuta ratha, Pallava Kailasa — reverses the well-attested attributions. The Palas patronised Nalanda in Bengal, not a Tamil-coast ratha, and the Chalukyas of Vatapi did not carve the Kailasa, so that pairing is also wrong.

5. (D) Kanauj's value was symbolic — holding it signalled paramountcy over the north, which is why even a Deccan power contested it, and the inability of any one of the three to keep it shows a balance of strong regional kingdoms. The Rashtrakutas had a flourishing Deccan kingdom (they built Ellora), so they did not lack a homeland. Kanauj was a prized seat, not a gold mine, so a purely economic-mining motive is invented. The Rashtrakutas were Indian rivals in the Tripartite Struggle, not Arab allies, and Sindh lay to the west, not along the Kanauj contest.

6. (C) A contest that no party can win permanently is the signature of several comparable powers checking one another — strength on all sides, not weakness. A single unbeatable empire would have ended the contest by winning, so that option contradicts the stalemate. Total collapse with no armies cannot produce a multi-generation military struggle at all. The Arabs were confined to Sindh and were not ruling the north, so the three were fighting each other for Kanauj, not jointly expelling Arabs.

7. (A) The Pratiharas guarded the north-west, and that very frontier role blocked Arab expansion beyond Sindh — so the reason is precisely why the assertion (consequences beyond their own kingdom) holds, making it a genuine cause-and-effect link. Saying the reason does not explain the assertion ignores that frontier-holding is exactly the mechanism of the wider consequence. The reason is historically accurate, so calling it false is wrong. The assertion is also accurate, since containing the Arabs shaped the whole period's history, so it is not false.

8. (A) Good source-criticism keeps the value of an eyewitness while recognising that his standpoint (a Buddhist monk) can colour emphasis, so the account is used and then tested against independent Indian evidence. Treating it as flawless ignores that any single source can be partial. Rejecting it wholesale discards genuinely useful testimony over a bias that only tilts emphasis, not erases truth. Making it the sole source and ignoring inscriptions and coins is the opposite of cross-checking and would leave the historian dependent on one viewpoint.

9. (D) A repulse decades before 712 and confinement for long after it together show repeated, effective Indian resistance that held the Arabs to Sindh. The 'no resistance, chose not to expand' option contradicts the very repulse and confinement the timeline records. The claim that they took most of India by 712 is false — only Sindh fell, so there was no large territory to withdraw from. Resistance came from Indian rulers such as the Gurjara-Pratiharas and Kashmir's Lalitaditya, not a Chinese army.

10. (C) The three records show distinct layers — a king granting land, a community maintaining a tank, and an elected sabha resolving disputes — interlocking into an organised order in which the king rules through institutions rather than personally. Personal management of every detail contradicts the existence of a self-governing sabha and a communal tank. Total village autonomy is wrong because a royal grant ties the village to the king and temple. Arab governors had no presence in the Chola south; their reach was limited to Sindh.

11. (C) Uttaramerur's inscriptions directly record the selection rules of a Chola sabha, making them firsthand and on-point, while Xuanzang's travelogue describes Harsha's north generally and is one outside observer's impression. Calling the travelogue fiction and inscriptions imaginative inverts the truth — both are real sources of different kinds. Xuanzang was a Chinese monk who wrote about northern India, not a Tamil writer barred from the north. The Uttaramerur texts describe an elected assembly's procedures, not a prashasti boasting of the king ruling each village himself.

12. (D) A ruling line rising from a humbler background and a profession crystallising into a jati both show movement and formation within the social order, which is the chapter's point that jati was flexible and changing. Calling caste completely rigid contradicts the very examples cited. Saying there were no jatis is false, since the Kayasthas are themselves named as a jati. The claim that everyone belonged to one identical group denies the many varied jatis the chapter describes.

13. (D) Brahmagupta (7th century, zero) precedes the 712 CE conquest of Sindh (8th century), which precedes Kalhana (12th century), giving zero, then Sindh, then the chronicle. Putting Sindh before zero reverses the 7th and 8th centuries. Putting the 12th-century chronicle first ignores that it is the latest of the three. Putting the chronicle before Sindh again misplaces the latest event in the middle.

14. (A) A guild with the means to fund repairs, a working tank, and a king redirecting its revenues together depict an active, coordinated economy, not a collapsed one. Silent barter with no guilds is contradicted by the very guild named in the record. Arab control is impossible here, since Arab presence stayed in Sindh. Claiming no organised water supply or commerce flatly denies the tank and the guild the inscription describes.

15. (D) Self-governing sabhas beneath samantas reveal a layered structure in which the king ruled through intermediaries rather than over each villager directly, which is a statement about the very nature of the monarchy. The sabhas did not abolish royal power or make India a republic — the king remained at the top of the layers. Sabhas were village assemblies, not gatherings of samantas, and they did not replace the king. There was no single national parliament in this age, so calling them its branches is an anachronism.

16. (D) The Pallavas ruled from Kanchi in the Tamil region and the Chalukyas from Vatapi (Badami) in the Deccan, and they were long-running rivals, each fostering temple art. Swapping them — Chalukyas at Kanchi, Pallavas at Vatapi — reverses their well-known seats. The Palas were a Bengal power, so neither Kanchi nor Vatapi was theirs. Vatapi was a Chalukya capital, not an Arab base, since the Arabs held only Sindh.

17. (B) The dark-age label is disproved by Indian creative and intellectual output; the Arab conquest is a foreign military action and so does not belong on a list of such achievements. The rules of zero are a landmark intellectual advance, so removing them would weaken, not fix, the list. The Bhakti hymns are a major cultural-religious development and clearly count. Keeping all five is wrong precisely because one item — a conquest — is of a different kind from the achievements the label-rebuttal needs.

18. (A) A gate-scholar testing applicants signals high standards, and monks travelling from distant lands signal international prestige, so together they show rigorous institutions linked to a wider Asian network. 'Open to anyone' contradicts the very examination the dvarapandita conducted. The guarded entry was an academic test, not a military checkpoint, so calling them disguised camps misreads it. Drawing students from across Asia is the opposite of being cut off and local.

19. (B) The Alvars were Vishnu-devotees and the Nayanars Shiva-devotees, so the quiz has swapped the two deities. Calling the statement correct keeps the error. Both groups were Hindu Bhakti saints, not Buddhists, so the Buddha option is wrong. They were Tamil poet-saints, not Chinese pilgrims or Arab generals, which confuses them with entirely different figures from the chapter.

20. (B) Bhakti's defining feature was accessible, personal devotion expressed in everyday local language, contrasting with the priest-led, sacrifice-centred formal Vedic tradition. Saying Bhakti was for kings only reverses its openness. Attributing the grand sacrifices to Bhakti and private devotion to Vedic ritual swaps the two traditions' features. Bhakti was an Indian devotional movement, not an Arab import, so that option is false.

21. (B) Granting tax rights to a temple and governing through a tribute-paying samanta both interpose intermediaries between king and subject, making authority layered and reliant on the loyalty of those intermediaries. Direct personal collection and governance is the opposite of what these arrangements describe. The king had not vanished — he still received tribute and troops and could make grants — so 'non-existent' is wrong. There was no nationwide vote in this age, so that option is anachronistic.

22. (A) Because a prashasti is written to glorify its ruler and can exaggerate, it cannot by itself settle a contested victory — so the reason is exactly why the assertion holds, a valid explanation. Saying the reason fails to explain ignores that exaggeration is precisely what makes one prashasti insufficient. The reason is accurate about prashastis, so it is not false. The assertion is also accurate, since cross-checking is needed, so it is not false.

23. (C) The Gurjara-Pratiharas guarded the north-west, the Rashtrakutas held the Deccan, and the Palas ruled Bengal in the east — the correct west-to-east sequence. The first wrong list misplaces the Palas in the north-west when they were in eastern Bengal. The second swaps the Rashtrakutas to the north-west and the Palas to the Deccan, neither of which fits. The fourth lists three Tamil southern powers, none of which guarded the north-west or held the Deccan in this contest.

24. (C) The flaw is methodological: a lone account can be biased or idealised, so it must be corroborated by independent evidence before prosperity is treated as proven. Xuanzang did travel across India, so claiming he never came is factually wrong. Sources can certainly indicate prosperity, so the blanket denial is mistaken. Written accounts are not automatically useless — coins, inscriptions and texts each contribute, and the rule is to combine them, not to crown coins alone.

25. (D) Monolithic means cut from one rock mass; carving an entire temple downward from a single block leaves no room for correcting errors, which is what makes Kailasa so remarkable. Assembly from marble bricks is the block-built method, the opposite of monolithic. Casting in iron and building in wood both describe materials and techniques other than carving stone, so neither matches 'monolithic' or the feat being praised.

26. (A) The struggle is called tripartite because the Rashtrakutas joined the Palas and Pratiharas in contesting Kanauj, making three contenders. The Cholas were a Tamil-south power not part of the Kanauj contest, so naming them as the third is wrong. The Guptas had ended well before this age and were not contestants. Saying only two powers sent armies contradicts the documented Rashtrakuta interventions that define the contest as three-sided.

27. (B) Every source has a perspective — royal documents flatter the king, and a traveller brings his own outlook — so the historian cross-checks them all, including against coins. Treating an outsider as automatically neutral ignores that travellers too can be partial or idealising. A prashasti's sacred setting does not make it exact; its purpose is praise. An

official grant is precisely the kind of self-serving royal document that needs corroboration, not blind trust.

28. (D) The chapter's measured claim is that some women and queens wielded real influence in public affairs, without asserting empire-wide sole rule by any of them. Saying women were entirely absent contradicts that very point. Claiming each queen ruled the whole subcontinent overstates far beyond the text. A decree forbidding any public role for women is invented and clashes with the noted influence of queens.

29. (D) Each claim fails: fragmentation coincided with flourishing culture, the Arabs took only Sindh (not most of India), and the Kanauj contest was three-sided among Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas — so all three are wrong. Saying none are wrong endorses three falsehoods. Saying only the struggle claim is wrong leaves the dark-age and 'most of India' errors standing. Saying only the dark-age claim is wrong wrongly accepts the Sindh and two-power errors.

30. (D) Epigraphy is the study of inscriptions on stone or metal (like copper-plate grants), and numismatics is the study of coins. Swapping them — epigraphy for coins, numismatics for inscriptions — reverses the definitions. The study of stars is astronomy, not epigraphy, and travel diaries are travelogues, not numismatic objects. Temple architecture is not numismatics, and travel diaries are not the subject of epigraphy, so the last pairing is wrong on both counts.

31. (B) The Rajatarangini is Kalhana's 12th-century chronicle of Kashmir's dynasties in chronological order, rare because formal narrative history was uncommon in early India. Brahmagupta wrote on mathematics, not a Kashmir history, so that attribution is wrong. An Alvar's Tamil devotional poem is a religious work, not a dynastic chronicle. An Arab account of Sindh is a different kind of source about a different region, not the Rajatarangini.

32. (D) The Palas backing universities and the Cholas codifying village assemblies show two distinct regional kingdoms each nurturing learning and institutions, so vitality was distributed, not concentrated. The 'only one northern empire' claim contradicts the existence of two different regional patrons. These kingdoms built and recorded institutions rather than destroying them. Arab rule was confined to Sindh, so it could not be the source of Pala universities or Chola assemblies.

33. (A) Correctly: a land grant produced a class of landholders, a samanta was a tribute-and-troops-paying subordinate ruler, and a sabha was a self-governing village assembly. The first wrong option swaps the meanings of samanta and sabha and inverts what a grant did. The second turns each administrative term into an unrelated object (poem, coin, temple). The third collapses three distinct institutions into one emperor, erasing the layered structure they describe.

34. (A) The correct pairings are Palas–Nalanda, Rashtrakutas–Ellora Kailasa, and Pallavas–Mahabalipuram rathas; the draft assigns each monument to the wrong dynasty, so none of its three pairings is right. 'Exactly one' or 'exactly two' would require at least one correct match, but every pairing in the draft is mismatched. 'All three' is plainly false for the same reason.

35. (B) The guide errs twice: there was no single empire (many regional kingdoms competed) and the age actively created new works (temples, universities, zero, Bhakti) rather than merely preserving. Keeping 'one empire' while only changing the tone leaves the political error intact. Accepting many kingdoms but calling the age stagnant leaves the cultural error intact. Saying nothing needs fixing endorses both mistakes.

36. (C) Only an Uttaramerur-type inscription directly records the selection procedure for a village sabha, so it proves the point on its own. A royal coin shows who ruled and his titles, not how a village picked its assembly. Xuanzang's travelogue concerns a different region and time and offers a broad impression, not Chola assembly rules. A ratha is a work of temple art and says nothing about assembly selection.

37. (C) Local grants and inscriptions document the concrete fabric of daily life — land, taxes, irrigation, assemblies — precisely the material grand chronicles skip, which is why they are prized for social history. They are local records, not the work of neutral foreigners, so the neutrality claim is wrong. They deal with administrative and communal matters, not kings' private feelings. Exaggeration is more typical of praise-poems; saying these humble records are the only exaggerating sources inverts the point.

38. (D) Extending the rebuttal needs achievements spread across the later centuries too — and the temples, universities and Bhakti movement supply exactly that, showing sustained creativity. Brahmagupta did not live for six centuries, so personal continuity is impossible. The rules of zero did not make building or learning unnecessary; the two are unrelated. Claiming nothing else happened concedes the dark-age view for later centuries, which is the opposite of supporting the rebuttal.

39. (C) A ratha is a chariot-shaped rock-cut shrine and a tank (eri) is a rainwater reservoir, so this pairing is correct. The first wrong option swaps the two meanings. The second turns a ratha into a samanta and a tank into a sabha, confusing four distinct terms. The third assigns a ratha to a university and a tank to a pilgrim, mixing unrelated categories entirely.

40. (A) Three separate courts each producing a major monument is direct evidence that multiple competing patrons enriched art — the historian's thesis. A single emperor commissioning all three contradicts the fragmentation that is her whole point. Arab funding is impossible, since Arab power stayed in Sindh and the works are Indian. Claiming building stopped until after 1200 CE denies the very monuments the period produced.

41. (B) It is true that the Arabs barely advanced beyond Sindh, but the stated reason is wrong — the cause was vigorous Indian resistance, not an absence of opposition and a free choice to halt. So 'both true' fails because the reason is false. 'Both false' fails because the assertion (limited advance) is correct. 'Assertion false' fails because the Arabs really were held to Sindh.

42. (B) The chapter's method is cross-checking: confidence comes from agreement among independent sources, not from any one source standing alone. The detailed, official prashasti is also the most flattering, so detail and officialdom do not make it self-sufficient. An eyewitness travelogue can still be partial or idealised. A coin is harder to fake but still reflects the issuing authority's claims, so it too needs corroboration.

43. (C) With no paramount emperor following Harsha, a vacuum opened over the north, and regional dynasties competed to fill it by seizing Kanauj — that is the causal link. Harsha's heirs did not stage an orderly succession contest; the struggle was a rivalry among separate dynasties. The Arabs, confined to Sindh, did not unseat Harsha's line at Kanauj. The struggle came after Harsha and did not end his reign, nor did it install a lasting single emperor — that is why it dragged on.

44. (C) A single identical group for everyone is the very opposite of a flexible, regionally varied system, so it does not support that description. A ruling line rising in status is direct evidence of mobility. A profession becoming a jati shows new jatis forming over time. Jatis multiplying and differing by region is textbook evidence of variation — so those three belong, and only the 'one identical group' claim does not.

45. (C) The rebuttal turns on bias: a prashasti exists to praise its ruler and can exaggerate, so it is not the most trustworthy single window and needs cross-checking. The claim that inscriptions are unreadable is false — historians read them, which is how we know their boastful content. Royal inscriptions record deeds and grants, not merely weather and crops. They were not all destroyed; many survive and are central evidence, so that option is also wrong.

46. (A) Drawing scholars from across Asia is the mark of connection, not isolation, and an entrance examination signals high standards, so both halves of the student's conclusion are contradicted. Saying the draw proves isolation reverses its plain meaning. The facts are well attested, not inventions. Although the universities sat in Bengal, the point is precisely that their standards and international reach are documented there, so they do speak to academic standing.

47. (C) Because rule was exercised through samantas, royal power hinged on their loyalty, and a samanta turning independent is exactly the fragility of an indirect, layered system. The king had not been governing the frontier personally — that is why a samanta held it. Samantas did owe tribute and troops, so withholding tribute did break the arrangement. There was no nationwide vote in this age, so that option is anachronistic and irrelevant.

48. (D) The Rashtrakuta Kailasa at Ellora is the chapter's prime example of an entire temple carved from a single rock mass. Nalanda was a brick-and-stone monastic university built up, not carved from one rock, so the Palas do not fit this specific claim. The Pratiharas are remembered for guarding the north-west, not for monolithic rock-cut temples. Chola tanks were excavated reservoirs for water, not rock-cut temples, so they do not embody temple-carving.

49. (A) The accurate picture is a single province — Sindh — held from 712 CE, with Indian resistance preventing wider expansion. The claim of conquering and directly ruling the whole subcontinent into modern times is the classic exaggeration the chapter refutes. Saying they held nothing at all denies the capture of Sindh. Saying they ruled Bengal and the Tamil south but not Sindh inverts the facts, since Sindh was precisely the one place they did hold.

50. (A) The accurate summary joins three correct points: political fragmentation, cultural flourishing, and Arab control limited to Sindh. The first wrong sentence falsely asserts one empire and cultural decline. The second falsely gives the Arabs most of India. The third falsely asserts a single empire and denies the Arab hold on Sindh. Only the option that gets all three right is acceptable.

51. (B) The chain is sound: Pratihara frontier defence contained the Arabs in Sindh, and that containment indeed left the interior to develop under regional Indian kingdoms. Claiming containment invited deeper conquest reverses cause and effect. The Pratiharas were an Indian dynasty defending against the Arabs, not Arab governors of Sindh. The interior was governed by Indian kingdoms, not directly by the Arabs, so the chain's conclusion stands.

52. (C) Grants organising landholding, guilds organising trade, and tanks organising water together signal a productive, deliberately managed economy. 'Total ruin' is contradicted by all three institutions. A purely barter economy is contradicted by organised merchant guilds. Arab control is impossible, since Arab presence was limited to Sindh, so the interior economy was not run from there.

53. (A) Harsha was the last to dominate the north, and the very reason we can say so is that afterwards no single emperor held it, forcing a multi-power contest for Kanauj — so the reason explains the assertion. Saying the reason is unrelated misses that the post-Harsha contest is the proof of his being last. Claiming one emperor dominated after him contradicts the Tripartite Struggle. Claiming many dominant emperors followed likewise contradicts the documented vacuum.

54. (B) Zero (intellectual), Nalanda (educational) and Uttaramerur (civic) together show advance on three fronts during the age of many kingdoms, jointly refuting both the dark-age label and the idea that institutions were absent. A single emperor did not produce them — they arose under different regional patrons. Arab rule was confined to Sindh and

produced none of them. Far from collapse, all three are evidence of vitality, so the 'collapse' lesson is the opposite of what they show.

55. (B) Mahabalipuram lies on the Tamil coast and its rock-cut rathas are Pallava works, so both halves are right. Ellora's Deccan Kailasa is a Rashtrakuta temple, not a Pala university, so that pairing is wrong on the dynasty. Nalanda in Bengal was a Pala Buddhist university, not a Rashtrakuta chariot-temple, so it is wrong on the feature and dynasty. Vatapi was in the Deccan and a Chalukya capital, not a Tamil-region Pallava one, so its place and dynasty are both wrong.

56. (B) The statement is specifically about lasting grandeur in stone, so the Ellora Kailasa — a surviving monolithic stone temple — is the precise counter-example. Brahmagupta's zero is a mathematical achievement, not a stone building, so it cannot rebut a claim about stone. The Alvars' hymns are devotional poems, not carved stone works. The Arab conquest of Sindh did not scatter lasting stone monuments across India and is not an Indian building achievement, so it fails as a counter-example.

57. (C) The label 'regional kingdoms' fits because the land held many genuine, competing states — each with court, army and patrons — yet none became an all-India empire. Saying there were no organised states ignores the documented kingdoms and their institutions. Saying one empire's provinces are mistaken for kingdoms denies the real rivalries like the Tripartite Struggle. Saying India was only Arab provinces is false, since Arab rule was limited to Sindh.

58. (C) The correct verdict is consistent and accurate: political division coexisting with creative culture sponsored by rival kingdoms. The 'unified empire that produced no art' verdict both misstates the politics and offers a self-contradictory reason. The 'stateless age that built universities without kings' verdict contradicts itself, since the universities had royal patrons like the Palas. The 'total foreign rule yet Indian patrons' verdict is internally contradictory — foreign rule and Indian patrons cannot both be total here, and Arab rule was confined to Sindh.

59. (B) Each source is suited to a different question: a praise-poem shows royal self-image, a village inscription shows local self-government, and a traveller's diary gives an outsider's impression needing corroboration. Swapping the prashasti and inscription misassigns each to the other's strength. Saying a foreign travelogue best reveals exact village assembly rules ignores that the on-the-spot inscriptions are the firsthand source for that. Calling all three interchangeable erases the very source-criticism the chapter teaches.

60. (A) The chapter shows the age held both threads together: Bhakti expressed devotion in everyday local languages while universities like Nalanda linked India to scholars across Asia, so the 'either/or' premise is false. Calling the foreign scholars a legend denies the well-attested international draw of the universities. Claiming Bhakti's languages were imported reverses the fact that Bhakti's strength was its use of local speech. Saying neither

existed contradicts both the documented hymns and the documented universities, and fragmentation did not prevent culture from spreading.